



HUMANITAS
INSTITUTE

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: St. Francis De Sales School
School Website: <https://stfrancisnewark.org/>

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Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

Overall Classification: CLASSICAL**Executive Summary**

St Francis de Sales School (Newark, OH 43055) presents a clearly Catholic, classical-oriented program that centers faith, virtue formation, and a deliberately classical curriculum within a parish school context. Public-facing materials emphasize daily Catholic religious formation, liturgical life, and a classical curriculum, with explicit statements about evangelization, discipleship, and a sacred-liturgical learning environment. The school also highlights a strong partnership with families and active community opportunities (e.g., SPICE, EdChoice). While the site foregrounds core classical commitments (classical curriculum, Catholic formation, and communal worship), explicit references to some classical-methodologies (e.g., Great Books, Trivium/Quadrivium, or Socratic pedagogy) are less overt in the public material. Taken together, the school strongly aligns with classical Catholic education in multiple dimensions, with room to more visibly document certain classical-methodology specifics on its site.

Overall classification: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

- Executive-level takeaway: The school demonstrates robust Religious and Metaphysical Foundations and a strong formation goal, and it clearly commits to a classical framework in its mission and curriculum presentation. However, the public materials could be more explicit about some canonical classical elements (e.g., detailed articulation of the Trivium/Quadrivium, Great Books, and explicit Socratic pedagogy in upper grades) to reach a full, fully-documented CLASSICAL status. The presence of SPICE, EdChoice engagement, and a staff-focused mission strengthens the Parents & Community and Faculty dimensions. See category-by-category details below.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot**Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL**

Evidence - The school explicitly frames itself as Catholic and discusses daily religion, Masses, Eucharistic devotion, catechesis, prayer, and liturgical life as integral to daily schooling. Public pages describe daily religion instruction, Mass multiple days per week, Eucharistic Adoration, Rosary, Lectio Divina, and communal prayer. - Materials also emphasize evangelization, discipleship, and a sacramental worldview, with statements about formation in faith and a sacramental understanding of reality. - Foundational Catholic identity is reiterated in the “Our Mission” and “K-8 Classical Catholic Education” pages, including explicit articulation of a Catholic, ordered cosmos created in Christ and the centrality of religion to the curriculum.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present in public materials: Catholic, Mass, liturgy, prayer, adoration, Lectio Divina, catechesis, evangelization, discipleship, sacred, sacramental, worship, liturgical. These map to the Positive Keyword Indicators for Religious and Metaphysical Foundations (truth, goodness, beauty; theology; liturgy; wonder; sacramental worldview). The knowledge lexicon lists terms like theology, liturgy, sacred music, worship, and the sacraments as positive signals; these are all evident on the site. - Negative keywords: none evident in the public materials (no relativism, secular humanism, or secular ethics signals observed in these pages).

Why this rating - The school’s materials overtly bind the educational project to Catholic theology, liturgy, and communal worship, with explicit statements of evangelization and discipleship. This maps directly to the

Religious and Metaphysical Foundations category as Classical in orientation, given the strong transcendental and liturgical framework. The absence of secular or relativistic signals in the public materials supports a Classical alignment in this domain.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school explicitly emphasizes formation of the whole person and spiritual growth as central aims, not merely information or workforce outcomes. The public materials recount a focus on “the integral formation of the whole human person—body, mind, and spirit” and the pursuit of spiritual growth through a Catholic framework. - The mission framing describes education as formation in virtue and wisdom, aligning with the telos of classical education. The “Our Mission” language emphasizes evangelization, virtue, and the pursuit of spiritual growth alongside academic excellence. - The school presents a classical curriculum as part of its identity, indicating a formation-oriented pedagogy consistent with classical aims (not merely job preparation).

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: formation, virtue, wisdom, liberal education, telos, contemplation/scholé, great conversation, classical mission, moral imagination, eternal truths. The Six Essentials lexicon explicitly lists formation, virtue, and the pursuit of truth/goodness/beauty as positive indicators; the school’s public statements align with these. - Negative keywords: none observed in the public materials in this category (no emphasis on career-readiness or job-market metrics that would signal non-classical aims).

Why this rating - The materials consistently present formation of virtue and wisdom as the primary goal, with explicit references to integral formation and a classical educational framework rooted in Catholic spirituality. This aligns strongly with Classical aims for this category.

Element 3: School Curriculum — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school presents itself as offering a “classical curriculum” within a Catholic framework, with emphasis on a unified Catholic education for K-8, and a core curriculum that places Religion at the center of all subjects. The Core Academic Curriculum page states that religion is the heart of every subject, and that the cosmos is ordered in Christ, signaling a classical, teleological approach to curriculum design. - The site explicitly uses the term “K-8 Classical Catholic Education,” signaling alignment with classical curriculum concepts. The “Core Academic Curriculum” page and related sections indicate a strong classical orientation. - The public material signals integration of faith with subject matter, and mentions the classical identity of the school’s curriculum, though detailed lists of the Trivium/Quadrivium or Great Books are not exhaustively enumerated on the visible pages.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: classical curriculum, K-8 Classical Catholic Education, liberal education (via classical framing), Great Books / Great Conversation (presence is implied in the classical orientation but explicit mention is not consistently visible across all public pages; the canonical Great Books language is not consistently explicit in all pages reviewed). The knowledge lexicon includes Great Books, primary sources, and the Great Conversation as positive indicators; the public site demonstrates a classical framing but does not consistently advertise Great Books by name in every page. - Negative keywords: The site does not emphasize social studies-centric framing, STEM-first framing, or project-based dominance in a way that would trigger negative signals in this category. The lack of explicit Great Books mention on every curricular page is noted as a potential gap (see below). The Six Essentials Negative Keywords list mentions “lack of Great Books and Historical Engagement” as a negative signal. The public materials show a classical frame but with limited explicit Great Books references across all pages.

Why this rating - The school clearly presents a classical curriculum orientation and a Catholic, integrated approach to curriculum. However, to push this to a full CLASSICAL rating in a strict rubric, more explicit, consistently visible references to core classical elements (e.g., grammar/logic/rhetoric in daily practice, explicit Great Books/Great Conversation commitments, and a clearly articulated Trivium/Quadrivium framework)

would be ideal. The current evidence supports SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL due to strong classical framing and religious integration, with room to make all classical elements explicit on the site.

Element 4: School Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public materials emphasize a pedagogy aligned with classical aims, including communal and liturgical practices, and a faith-centered community where students are formed through a combination of contemplative and active practices. The presence of liturgical life, daily prayer, and a mission to form the whole person suggests a pedagogy that values contemplation, disciplined formation, and community discipline. The SPICE program further signals a focus on inclusive formation and a humane approach to teaching. - The classical Catholic framing includes a suggestion of a pedagogy that integrates formation with content, including a disciplined religious formation alongside academic content. The site's "Is Classical Catholic Education Relevant?" and "Characteristics" pages indicate a pedagogy oriented toward a traditional, formation-forward approach.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: Scholé/restful contemplation, memory work/recitation, liturgical integration, formation through imitation, reverence/wonder, catechesis, and reverence. The knowledge lexicon lists terms like Socratic dialogue, memorization/recitation, and memory work as positive indicators for pedagogy, while signaling potential negatives like over-emphasis on experiential/constructivist approaches. The public site demonstrates a strong emphasis on prayer, liturgy, and a formation-forward pedagogy, with less explicit emphasis on Socratic seminars or explicit recitation-based memory work in the visible pages. - Negative keywords: The site does not foreground an exclusively project-based, experiential-only pedagogy; however, explicit Socratic seminars and dialogues are not consistently advertised across the visible pages (which keeps this category from a full Classical classification). The public pages do not strongly advertise project-based or constructivist-only approaches.

Why this rating - The pedagogy leans toward a classical formation approach, combining contemplative and liturgical elements with curricular aims. The lack of explicit, consistent documentation of particular classical teaching methods (e.g., explicit, repeated Socratic seminars or rigorous usage of memory work across the upper grades) means the site remains "SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL" rather than fully CLASSICAL in pedagogy.

Element 5: School Faculty — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The site highlights a staff that is dedicated to Catholic education and committed to excellence, with explicit statements about faculty quality and a staff focus as integral to the school's mission. One page notes: "Our staff is dedicated to Catholic Education. They bring years of experience and a true love of Jesus to our school. We strive every day for academic excellence with rigorous instruction and the best teaching practices." This indicates faculty as the living curriculum and a core facet of the school's classical identity. - The site includes a Staff Directory page, reinforcing the sense of a community of teachers who model virtues and are central to the school's culture.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: model teachers, mentors, living curriculum, faculty of friends, portrait of a teacher, collegial culture, character formation, virtue, mentorship, teacher as guide. The public materials articulate a clear, formation-focused faculty philosophy, consistent with classical indicators. The knowledge lexicon lists these as positive signals for the Faculty category. - Negative keywords: none observed.

Why this rating - The school presents a robust, formation-forward faculty narrative with explicit commitment to virtue and a living-curriculum approach, aligning strongly with CLASSICAL expectations for Element 5.

Element 6: School Parents & Community — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school emphasizes partnerships with families and parent formation, including open campus opportunities, and parent involvement through programs like SPICE (Special People in Catholic Education) and community activities. SPICE explicitly describes a parish-and-school-based program to support diverse

learners and an inclusive learning environment, signaling a family/community formation approach. The EdChoice programs also indicate active family engagement through scholarships and enrollment support. - The site discusses parent involvement more generally through the mission and through material about admission/tuition and EdChoice, indicating a family-centric approach to schooling and a willingness to engage parents as partners in education. The public pages describe a faith-filled community and a culture of discipleship that invites family involvement.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: partnership with families, co-teachers, parental engagement, parent formation, family involvement, home-school collaboration, parent-training, community of learners. These map to the Positive Keyword Indicators in the Six Essentials lexicon. SPICE materials explicitly articulate partnership and parental involvement; EdChoice-related pages reflect a family-centered enrollment approach. - Negative keywords: none observed in public materials. The site does not present parent-as-customer or minimal-parent-involvement signals.

Why this rating - The public materials show explicit, actionable steps toward parent involvement and family partnership (SPICE, EdChoice, enrollment communications), aligning with classical community-building expectations. However, the documentation could further illuminate a formal, explicit “parents as co-teachers” framework visible on the site to push this category to a full CLASSICAL rating.

What would move the needle

- Make Great Books, the Trivium (grammar/logic/rhetoric), and Great Conversation themes explicit on the public site across multiple pages, with concrete examples of how these are woven into daily K-8 learning, to elevate Element 3 from SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL to CLASSICAL.
 - Provide explicit references to Socratic pedagogy, especially in upper grades, with sample seminar structures, topics, and assessment practices, to move Element 4 toward CLASSICAL.
 - Strengthen and publicly surface an explicit “parents as co-teachers” framework (beyond SPICE and enrollment materials), including parent formation programs, at-home learning guidance, and regular parent-partnership events to push Element 6 toward CLASSICAL.
 - Include a clear articulation of the classical curriculum sequence (grammar/logic/rhetoric progression in K-12, with explicit historical engagement and Great Books plan) on the Core Curriculum pages to reinforce Element 3 as CLASSICAL.
 - Publish a concise, catchy synthesis of the school’s classical pedagogy, including references to memory work, recitation, and liturgical integration, to strengthen Element 4 and Element 5 alignment in public materials.
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Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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